# The Complete Works of William Shakespeare (abridged) [revised]

**By Adam Long, Daniel Singer and Jess Winfield (The Reduced Shakespeare Co)**

***PLAYWRIGHTS' NOTE:*** *The script is written for three actors. In performance, the actors should substitute their own names for "Adam," "Jess," and "Daniel." Where Shakespearean characters appear in the script, the character name is preceded by the actor's initial (ie A/Juliet means Adam is playing Juliet, etc.) "Shakespearean" dialogue appears in double quotation marks ("").*

*Because the show comments on contemporary events to place Shakespeare's works in a modern context, it's absolutely essential to keep the show fresh and timely by updating the many topical references as events warrant. Have some fun and come up with your very own put-downs of annoying famous people where required . . . And do it FASTER!*

## INTRODUCTION

**(Pg 1-2)** *Hello and welcome to this performance! [I am] about to attempt a feat which [I] believe to be unprecedented in the history of civilization. To capture, in a single theatrical experience, the magic . . . The genius . . . The towering grandeur of 'The Complete Works of William Shakespeare.'* [Now, we know that] **(Pg 4)** *our society's capacity to comprehend the genius of William Shakespeare has been systematically *compromised* by soap operas . . . and vandalized by video games . . . But have no fear! (In the manner of a fire-and-brimstone evangelist) [I am] on a mission from God to spread the holy word of the Bard to the masses.* **(Pg 6)** *Now, without further ado, I am proud to present.*

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**JESS:** **(Pg 14)** From Tybalt's death onwards, the lovers are curs'd, despite the best efforts of Friar and Nurse; their fate pursues them, they can't seem to duck it. . . And at the end of Act Five, they both kick the bucket. *(Juliet and Nurse enter)*

**A/JULIET:** **(Pg 15)** "O, it is my nurse. Now nurse, what news?"

**D/NURSE:** Alack the day! He's gone, he's kill'd, he's dead! O Romeo! I saw the wound with my own eyes.

**A/JULIET:** Is Romeo slaughter'd and is Tybalt dead?

**D/NURSE:** No, Romeo kill'd Tybalt, he is banished!

**A/JULIET:** God! Did Romeo's hand shed Tybalt's blood?

**D/NURSE:** "It did, it did, alas the day it did." *(She wails hysterically, runs two small laps around*

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*Juliet and exits – Jess enters as FRIAR LAURENCE)*

**A/JULIET:** O, Friar Laurence! Romeo is banished and Tybalt is slain and . . .

**J/FRIAR:** *(bored, he interrupts)* "Take thou this vial, and this distilled liquor drink thou off. And presently though thy veins shall run a cold and drowsy humor."

**A/JULIET:** **(Pg 16-17)** *(Takes bottle and drinks)* O, I feel a cold and drowsy humor running through my veins . . . *(Friar exits. Juliet becomes dizzy)* Mm, pretty colors! Uh-oh . . . *(Juliet vomits)* There, I feel much better. *(Collapses suddenly. ROMEO enters. He sees JULIET and rushes to her prone body, accidentally stepping on her crotch while doing so)*

**D/ROMEO:** "O, no! *(Adam clutches his privates in agony)* / My love, my wife! / Death, that hath suck'd the honey of thy breath, / Hath no power yet upon thy beauty. / Juliet, why art thou yet so fair?"

**A/JULIET:** Dunno, lucky I guess.

**D/ROMEO:** "Here's to my love. *(He drinks from his poison bottle.)* / O true apothecary! Thy drugs are quick. / Thus, with a kiss, I die ... *(Just as Daniel leans in to kiss Adam, Adam burps. Now Daniel has no wish to kiss Adam. He struggles with the problem for a moment, takes another swig of poison, and finally kisses him)* Thus with a kiss, I die." *(ROMEO dies. JULIET wakes up, stretches, scratches her butt, and looks around.)*

**A/JULIET:** Good morning. "Where, O where is my love? *(She sees him lying at her feet and screams)* "What's this? A cup, closed in my true love's hand? Poison I see hath been his timeless end. O, churl. Drunk all and left no friendly drop to help me after? Then I'll be brief. O happy dagger! This is thy sheath." *(She unsheathes ROMEO'S dagger and does a doubletake: the blade is tiny)* That's Romeo for ya.

*(JULIET stabs herself. She screams, but, to her surprise, she does not feel injured. She looks for a wound and can't find one. Finally, she realizes that the blade is retractable. This is a cause for much joy. She stabs herself gleefully in the torso and on the crown of the head. Finally, she flings her happy dagger to the ground)*

**A/JULIET:** "There rust and let me die!"*(Dies)*

**JESS:** Epilogue!

**DANIEL:** "For never was there a story of more woe / Than this of Juliet and her Romeo"

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*(singing)* And Romeo and Juliet are deeeeaad . . . !

## TRANSITION

*I shall now move on to explore the genius evident in Shakespeare's more mature plays, as I present his dark and brooding tragedy, 'Othello, the Moor of Venice.'*

**ADAM:** *(He beat-boxes, then raps)* **(Pg 21-24)** Here's the story of a brother by the name of Othello / He liked white women and he liked . . . limoncello.

**JESS:** *(catching on quickly)* Oh, yeah, yeah. Uh . . . / And a punk named Iago who made hisself a menace / 'Cos he didn't like Othello, the Moor of Venice.

**ADAM:** Now Othello got married to Des-demona,

**JESS:** But he took off for the wars and he left her alone-a.

**ADAM:** It was a moan-a

**JESS:** A groan-a

**ADAM:** He left her alone-a.

**DANIEL:** *(finally catching on and joining in)* He didn't write a letter and he didn't telephone-a! / *(They all get into it, making boom-box noises and adopting a hip-hop attitude)* Now Othello loved Desi like Adonis loved Venus.

**JESS:** And Desi loved Othello cuz he had a big . . .

**DANIEL:** SWORD!

**ADAM:** But Iago had a plan that was clever and slick / He was crafty

**JESS:** He was sly

**DANIEL:** He was sort of a _____ *(Not wanting to say it)*

**ADAM:** He say 'I'm gonna shaft the Moor.'

**DANIEL:** How you gonna do it? Tell us!

**ADAM:** Well, I know his tragic flaw is that he's

**JESS:** Too damn jealous!

**ADAM:** I need a dupe / I need a dope / I need a kind of a shmoe . . .

**JESS:** So he find a chump sucker by the name o' Cassio.

**DANIEL:** And he plants on him Desdemona's handkerchief

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**ADAM:** So Othello gets to wonderin' just maybe if . . . While he been out fightin'

**DANIEL:** Commandin' an army

**JESS:** Are Desi and Cass playin hide the salami?

**ADAM:** Sa-sa-sa-salam Salaaammii!

**DANIEL:** So he come back home an' he mother the beeyotch. *(Can "bleep" out this word")*

**JESS:** An' he thinks he pulled it off, without a heeyotch.

**ADAM:** But there's Emilia at the do'.

**JESS:** Who we met in Act Fo'.

**DANIEL:** Who say, 'You big dummy, she weren't no whore. She was **JESS:** Pure

**DANIEL:** She was **JESS:** Clean

**DANIEL:** She was **JESS:** Virginal, too,

**DANIEL:** So why'd you have to go and make her face tum blue?

**ADAM:** And Othello say:

**JESS:** 'Damn, this is getting' pretty scary.'

**DANIEL:** So he pulled out his blade and committed hari-kiri. *(Jess mimes hara-kiri on himself and twitches in death throes) [NOTE the following 4 lines are from the original (Pg 36), rather than the revised script]*

**ADAM:** Iago got caught, but he prob'ly copped a plea,

**JESS:** *(Singing)* [And he] Loaded up his bags,

**DANIEL:** And moved to Beverly . . .

**JESS:** . . .Hills, that is. *(Bows and elaborate handshakes all round.)*

**ADAM:** *(Raised-fist salute)* **(Pg 28)** Tragedies! *(Daniel clears his throat because that was inappropriate; Adam with a much smaller fist-salute)* Tragedies.

**DANIEL:** 'The Scottish play!'

**ADAM:** Oh yeah! Mac –

**DANIEL:** Shhhhh! Don't say it! It's cursed. It's bad luck to say the name of that show unless you're performing it. That's why we refer to it is 'The Scottish Play.'

**ADAM:** But we ***are*** performing it.

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**DANIEL:** **(Pg 29-31)** *(shrugs)* We now present our authentically Scottish production of . . . Macbeth!

**D/WITCH:** "Double, double, toil and trouble." *(In nearly impenetrable Scottish accents)*

**J/MACBETH:** Stay, ye imperrrfect macspeaker. Tell me more.

**D/WITCH:** Macbeth, Macbeth, beware Macduff. / None of woman born shall harm Macbeth / Till Birnam Wood come to Dunsinane, don't ye know. *(WITCH exits. ADAM enters as MACDUFF)*

**J/MACBETH:** Och, that's dead great. Then macwhat macneed macfear of Macduff? *(MACDUFF wields his sword and throws a two-fingered gesture at MACBETH)*

**A/MACDUFF:** See YOU, Jimmy, *(a popular Scottish oath)* and know / That Macduff was from his mother's womb untimely ripped!" / What d'ye think about that? *(They spar)*

**J/MACBETH:** Och! I do nae like it, but I support a woman's right t'choose! Lay on, ye great haggis-breath! *(They fence)*

**A/MACDUFF:** Ah, Macbeth! Ye killed my wife, ye murdered me wee bairns, and ye did poop in my soup.

**J/MACBETH:** Och! I didnae!

**A/MACDUFF:** Och, aye, ye did. I had t' throw half of it away. *(MACDUFF chases MACBETH offstage where MACBETH'S scream is abruptly cut off. MACDUFF re-enters carrying a severed head)* "Behold where lies the usurper's cursed head." Macbeth, yer arse is out the windie. *(Dropkicks the head offstage.)* And know, That never was there a story of blood and death / Than this, o' Mister and Mrs. Macbeth. Thankee. *(Exits)(JESS enters)*

**JESS:** Meanwhile, in ancient Rome, Julius Caesar was a much beloved tyrant. *(ADAM enters)* All hail, Julius Caesar! *(DANIEL enters as JULIUS CAESAR)*

**D/CAESAR:** Hail, citizens!

**JESS:** . . . Who was warned by a soothsayer . . .

**A/SOOTHSAYER:** "Beware the Ides of March."

**JESS:** The great Caesar, however, chose to ignore the warning.

**D/CAESAR:** What the h*** are the Ides of March?

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**A/SOOTHSAYER:** The 15th of March.

**D/CAESAR:** Why, that's today. *(ADAM stabs him repeatedly. He falls)* "Et tu, Brute?" *(CAESAR dies. JESS becomes MARK ANTONY, orating over the body.)*

**J/ANTONY:** Friends, Romans, countrymen, lend me your ears. I come to bury Caesar.

**ADAM:** **(Pg 34-38)** Bo-ring!

**DANIEL:** This is the kind of stuff that kids hate to study in school because it's so boring.

**ADAM:** I'm sorry, guys, but I promised I would not do dry, boring Shakespeare. I love these people, and I don't want to see them get turned off to Shakespeare. *(gesturing to audience)* That's what happened to me. When I was in school, and we were supposed to be studying Shakespeare, I'd be looking out the window at all the kids playing ball, and I'd be thinking to myself, 'Why can't this Shakespeare stuff be more like sports?'

**DANIEL:** How do you mean?

**ADAM:** Well, sports are exciting. Engaging. I mean, take the histories, for example. With all those kings knocking each other off, running up and down the field, the throne passing from one guy to the next – it's exactly like football, but you do it with a crown.

**DANIEL:** Hey, they are kinda similar, aren't they? Okay, line 'em up. Let's kick some royal . . . *(Jess pulls out a whistle and blows it)(They line up in a football formation – then like a quarterback calling signals)* Twenty-five! Forty-two! Richard the Third! Henry the Fourth, Part One, Part Two . . . HUT!

**JESS***:* . . . And the crown is snapped to Richard the Second, that well-spoken fourteenth-century monarch. He's fading back to pass, looking for an heir downfield, but there's a heavy rush from King John. *(JESS as KING JOHN stabs DANIEL as RICHARD)*

**D/RICHARD II:** "My gross flesh sinks downwards!"

**JESS:** The crown is in the air, and Henry the Sixth comes up with it!

**A/HENRY VI:** Victory is mine!

**D/ANNOUNCER:** But he's hit immediately by King John. Oh no! He's cutting Henry the Sixth into three parts, that's gotta hurt! *(KING JOHN slices up HENRY)* This could be the end of the War of the Roses cycle! *(KING JOHN grabs the crown and runs in place with it)*

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**A/ANNOUNCER:** King John is in the clear . . . He's at the forty, the thirty, the twenty – *(DANIEL sneaks up from behind and pantomimes pouring something into JESS's mouth)* -- ooh, but he's poisoned on the ten yard line! *(DANIEL snatches the crown and puts it on. JESS exit.)* Looks like he's out for the game. Replacing him now is number seventy-two, King Lear.

**D/LEAR:** To Regan and Goneril I hand off my kingdom. Cordelia, you go long . . . *(JESS re-enters as referee, throwing a penalty flag and blowing a whistle.)*

**A/ANNOUNCER:** There's a penalty marker! *(JESS makes a hand signal and points at LEAR)* Fictional character on the field. Lear is disqualified, and he's not happy about it.

**D/LEAR:** *(Disappointed)* Bastards! *(Jess "bleeps" the profanity)*

**ADAM:** Lining up now is that father-son team of Henry the Fourth and Prince Hal. Center snaps to the quarterback . . . quarterback gives to the hunchback. It looks like Richard the Third's limp is giving him trouble.

**D/RICHARD III: "**A horse, a horse! My kingdom for a horse!"

**A/ANNOUNCER:** There's a pile-up on the field.

**D/ANNOUNCER:** FUM-BLE!!! And Henry the Eighth comes up with it. He's at the fifteen, the ten. . . He stops at the five to chop off his wife's head . . . TOUCHDOWN for the Red Rose! Oh, my! You gotta believe this is the beginning of a Tudor Dynasty!

**CHEERLEADER:** Henry the Fifth, Richard the Third, the whole royal family's frickin' absurd! Goooo, [insert local sports team] Yay!

**ADAM:** Can I have some house lights please? *(consults a large book of SHAKESPEARE PLAYS)*

**DANIEL:** What are you doing?

**ADAM:** I just want to check the list of plays. I think we might have done' em all already. Yea, see, we did all the histories just now. 'Romeo and Juliet' we did-

**DANIEL:** *(looking over his shoulder)* 'Julius Caesar,' right-

**ADAM:** We rapped 'Othello,' Lear was in the football game, 'Macbeth' we did with Scottish accents.

**DANIEL:** The comedies ? . . . .

**ADAM**: Eh . . . let's skip [them]. And that's it, right? That's all of them!

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**JESS:** Hey, no, you guys . . . *(Points to a title on the list)*

**DANIEL:** Hamlet!

**ADAM:** Shakespeare didn't write Hamlet. *(Shocked looks from the others)* What's it about?

**JESS:** You know, the young prince struggling with his conscience after his uncle murders his father?

**ADAM:** Dude, that's The Lion King. **(Pg 39)** I don't wanna do it!

**JESS:** Look, our show's called The Complete Works of William Shakespeare.

**ADAM:** Okay, so we'll call it 'The Complete Works of William Shakespeare Except Hamlet.' *(Looks from the others)*

**ADAM:** You can't make me do it! You can't! **(Pg 40)** *(ADAM springs toward the exit)*

**JESS:** Get back here, you Shakespeare weenie!

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## AWARD HISTORY

***2003National Qualifier***
***2004 National Qualifier***
***2005 National Qualifier***
***2006 National Qualifier***
***2007 National Qualifier***
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